

A Hero's Welcome

Our time in Australia included very little tourist-type activity. Some nice dinners out, a couple of long, lazy visits to *Kings Park* and a whole lot of time spent in the hotel room being anything but lazy. For reasons I can no longer think of, I made Danni wait much too long for this, and she insisted on making up for lost time.

I was only too happy to oblige.

I read a theory somewhere that having sex with someone is best the second time around. When the first-time clumsiness was gone but the experience was still new and exciting. My limited research on the subject supported that hypothesis... until now. Being with Danni was utterly fantastic and only getting better. I wanted her. All the time. To the point where I'm training myself to resist... and I've discovered that I kind of like that, too. Fighting the pull is a thrill all it's own.

Today was going to be a real test, though. Our first day back to work. A whole eight hours, at the minimum. Could I make it?

Easily. Waiting makes things better, and Danni was worth waiting for.

She bumped the Audi into the RSI lot, and put it in her reserved spot. Normally little more than a status symbol because she gets in so early, it was a useful perk today because we were pretty late.

Seems we had a lot of trouble getting dressed and staying that way.

As we walked up to the main entrance, I paused and looked around.

She's not much to look at, this gym of ours. Clean and well-cared for, but otherwise unremarkable. Nothing about it gave even the slightest hint of the things that happened here. The relationships. The drama. The triumphs and the heartbreak.

In her customary fashion, Danni read my thoughts without either of us saying a word.

"It's a helluva thing you've built," she said.

"We've built," I corrected.

She nodded absently and let it go.

Then she slipped her hand into mine.

"Shall we?" she asked.

And that's the way we went in. Hand in hand, like high school sweethearts.

We stepped into the lobby and found... nothing. Not a soul in sight.

A little weird since the state of the parking lot said just about everyone was here, but they were probably all hard at work.

We continued toward our offices without a second thought. We were halfway there then the music started.

Eye Of The Tiger by Journey, playing from a pair of wireless speakers nestled in the decorative vegetation.

Danni pulled her hand away instantly.

"What did you do?" she asked.

"Me? Nothing."

The look on her face said she didn't believe me.

"What?" I protested. "I've been with you the whole time."

I was saved from further interrogation when the real culprits made their entrance. I spotted Emily first, as she emerged from the training floor with a trail of RSI fighters behind her. Emma and Tiffany headed up another group coming out of the short hallway that led to the locker rooms. Another small crowd suddenly appeared on the mezzanine in front of the upstairs conference rooms... Steph, Trish and Marcy prominent among them.

The advance stopped about six feet away... forming a nearly perfect semi-circle with Danni and I at it's center.

Then they started with the applause. And the cheering. A literal standing ovation.

I took a few big steps to my left. Danni tried to grab me, but I skittered out of reach. Then I turned and joined in with the others.

She shot me another withering look.

"Hey, I didn't do it," I said. "Doesn't mean I don't like it."

She stood there for a while. One hand on her hip and the other covering her mouth. She looked like she wanted to scream.

Then I saw the smile in her eyes as she gave it up.

And why the hell wouldn't she? This wasn't a public display. We were all family here.

After a while she waved her arms in a defeated, *well come on... let's get this over with* kind of gesture.

And out they came. Forward, down and around. She was surrounded and engulfed in no time... and I somehow got shoved back to the middle with the surge.

RSI's team leader wasted no time sharing the spotlight - plucking the other four new champions out of the crowd and into the center with her. They, in turn, dragged the rookies in.

Then the party was on.

That's exactly what it felt like, too. The whole stable chatting and dancing and celebrating. Like a Christmas party in October.

The song ended. Though I'd already said it all in Australia, I thought maybe it would be appropriate for me to say a few words.

Then Emma was suddenly behind me, pushing me right up next to Danni.

A new song started. Michael Bublé's cover of *Such A Night*.

Danni and I let out a simultaneous sigh.

Bitches.

Apparently, titles weren't the only thing the women of RSI planned to celebrate today.

I looked at her for commiseration, but found myself drawn in by those happy brown eyes instead.

She had given up. I guess I had to, as well.

*It was a night
Oh what a night it was
It really was such a night*

I felt the pull. I let it carry me.

*Oh the moon was bright
Oh how bright it was
It really was such a night*

I took a step her way. Nice and close. We put our arms around each other.

*Oh the night was alight
with stars above
Mmmm when she kissed me*

I had to fall in love

We kissed. Right there in front of God and everyone.

Why the hell wouldn't we? We were all family here.

Mmmm it was a kiss

Ooh it was a kiss it was

It really was such a kiss

Oh how she could kiss

Oh what a kiss it was

It really was such a kiss

Then a cheer went up from the crowd and kind of ruined the moment.

We broke apart, but Danni grabbed my hands and held on. Next thing I knew, we were caught up in the bounce of the melody. Others around us started to dance, as well.

The chorus kicked in with a crescendo of horns. Danni got an evil grin on her face.

Oh, no.

She spun me out, then pulled me back in.

"Don't you dare dip me... don't you dare dip me... don't you dare dip me!"

She dipped me - much to the delight of the women around us.

She pulled me upright. I raised an eyebrow at her.

"I hate you."

"That's not what you said last night."

Ohhh... my god.

Turns out the practically angelic Danneel Harris can be deliciously wicked when she wants to be.

We bounced to the music some more. I found myself unable to take my eyes off of her.

It was the kind of moment that makes you take stock of your blessings.

I was the owner of the stable of my dreams. Not only highly successful and overflowing with talent, but packed with good people who cared about each other.

I was in love with my best friend. A woman who had already shown a very high tolerance for my impulsive stupidity and unfounded neuroses, yet was also perfectly willing to step on me when I needed it.

What more could I ask for?

Tomorrow always brings the possibility of some unforeseen disaster. But right now... even a professional pessimist like me had to admit things were pretty damn great.